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DiP Parent Guide

Congratulations, you are going to be a mom or dad (again)!

Through this guide we share the experiences and tips of colleagues who also have a family. Read how they experience fatherhood or motherhood in combination with work, discover which books you should really read and know who you can turn to for questions or to share any concerns you may have.

Good to know: this is a working document. If you have a great tip or experience to share, please contact HR (hr@digital-power.com)

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I’m having a child, what do I need to arrange?

Your life is turned upside down when you are having a child. We would love to think along with you about how to handle the new things that come your way. Continue reading to find answers to the most frequently asked questions.

I'm having a child, what do I need to arrange?

♀♂ Who should I inform at Digital Power?

Inform the colleague(s) you would like to tell first, but don't forget to inform HR as well (Annemiek, Astrid or Nadine). They can already give you a lot of information about what should and can be arranged through DiP, such as pregnancy leave, parental leave or additional birth leave. You can already look around on www.verlofregelaar.nl and this guide gives a lot of information already as well.

♀ What rights do I have as a pregnant employee until my leave?

If you are pregnant, you can take the following into account:

- You may not work for 4 weeks before and 6 weeks after giving birth.
- At DiP we try to accommodate your pregnancy as much as possible.
- You are entitled to extra breaks, but only a maximum of 1/8th of your daily working time.
- You are entitled to (paid) prenatal screening tests.

Your working hours and breaks may also be adjusted. You are entitled to the following, but always in consultation with HR:

- Extra breaks, up to 1/8th of your working time, until 6 months after delivery.
- A suitable, lockable room to rest (containing a bed or couch). If you need a lot of rest time, we recommend working from home.
- Prenatal screening tests when necessary during working hours. Your salary will continue to be paid for the duration of the prenatal screening test and travel time.

♀ What happens if I cannot work or work less due to pregnancy symptoms?

Of course, we always hope that every colleague has a successful pregnancy, but should you develop symptoms, it works the same as calling in sick. When you call in sick, indicate that the complaints are related to your pregnancy. The UWV has a safety net arrangement for this. HR also submits your sick report to the UWV, allowing us to reimburse your wage costs. You can also report partially sick. However, this is always done in consultation with HR.

♀ What about pregnancy- and maternity leave?

You are entitled to at least 16 weeks of pregnancy- and maternity leave. You stop 6, 5 or 4 weeks before your due date and after the delivery you are entitled to 10, 11 or 12 weeks maternity leave respectively. Once the baby is born, the final date of the end of your maternity leave can be determined. If your child is born a week later than the due date, you are automatically entitled to an additional week of maternity leave. Is your child born prematurely? Then you add the days your pregnancy leave was shorter to your maternity leave.

You request your pregnancy- and maternity leave through HR. Do not request it later than 2 weeks before your leave starts. However, usually we have discussed your wishes earlier on already.

During your pregnancy- and maternity leave, you are entitled to maternity benefits (called WAZO benefit). HR requests the benefit from the UWV and DiP receives it. DiP then continues to pay your

wages during your leave. As soon as the benefit has been applied for at the UWV, you will receive letters from the UWV with all the necessary information.

You can also take the last period of your maternity leave in parts. This is the leave that remains after 6 weeks from the date of your birth. You can spread this part of the leave over a maximum of 30 weeks. Of course, you do this in consultation with HR and the Operations Manager.

Additionally, since 8/1/2022, you are entitled to 9 weeks of paid parental leave. You can choose to take this leave, but it's not mandatory. This amount is based on a full-time position. You must take the leave within 1 year after the birth of your child. You can take this leave flexibly. If you have any paid parental leave hours remaining after 1 year, this balance will be added to the 17 weeks of unpaid parental leave.

♀ What happens if I get sick during or after my pregnancy- and maternity leave?

If you become sick during your leave due to pregnancy or childbirth, nothing changes. If you are still sick after your maternity leave, report this immediately on the 1st day you would start working again, HR will submit a request to the UWV to continue paying your wages. The UWV also has a safety net for this. As soon as this request is made, you will be contacted by the UWV.

⚥ What about partner leave?

After your partner gave birth, you are entitled to one working week of paid partner leave. If you work 5 days then you are entitled to 5 days, if you work 4 days then you are entitled to 4 days. You can request these days as special leave through My Insite and take them within 4 weeks after the birth of your child.

As a partner, you are also entitled to 5 working weeks of extended partner leave. You can opt for this, but it is not an obligation. You must take the leave within 6 months after the birth of your child and you must take it in full weeks. In consultation with HR and the Operations Manager, you can also spread the leave over a longer period than 5 weeks. You can also take less than 5 weeks of extended partner leave.

Additionally, since 8/1/2022, as a partner, you are entitled to 9 weeks of paid parental leave. You can choose to take this leave, but it's not mandatory. This amount is based on a full-time position. You must take the leave within 1 year after the birth of your child. You can take this leave flexibly. If you have any paid parental leave hours remaining after 1 year, this balance will be added to the 17 weeks of unpaid parental leave.

During the additional leave, you will be paid 70% of your salary. HR applies for the extended partner leave at the UWV and DiP receives the payment. DiP then continues to pay that 70% of your salary during your leave. Once the benefit has been requested from the UWV, you will receive letters from the UWV with all the necessary information. To pay your wages properly, you must add your child as a family member in My Insite and then request the extended partner leave via leave.

See page 21: types of leave for a complete overview of all types of (parental) leave.

⚥ What about upaid parental leave?

With unpaid parental leave, you temporarily work less to spend more time with your child until he/she is 8 years old. You are entitled to 26 times the number of hours you work per week (your schedule). You can take the parental leave as you wish. For example, you can work 50% less for a

year. But you can also take it in a shorter period of time (3 months full-time) or just spread it over a longer period of time (1 day per week). However, the parental leave must have a regular pattern. You cannot use parental leave as extra days off that you use randomly during the period. Parental leave always takes place in consultation with your Business Manager.

Parental leave must be requested in writing from HR no later than 2 months before you want to take the leave. Parental leave is a form of unpaid leave. Your salary is not paid. Parental leave always continues during the requested period. Does it coincide with a day of illness or a public holiday? Then that day counts as parental leave.

You do not accrue vacation or vacation pay while on parental leave.

⚥ Why should I choose unpaid parental leave instead of an adjustment in the hours of my contract?

You can opt for unpaid parental leave or work fewer hours by adjusting your schedule.

In both cases, the effect is the same in terms of hours and the amount you get paid less. At StiPP you do not accrue pension on your parental leave hours.

⚥ How do I request the different types of leave?

You do this via Afas Insite. Follow this manual:
https://digitalpower.sharepoint.com/:b:/s/Organisatie/EZ1Nnbc6OINNtSs6T2X_OxkBofLXWM5pq9UsmETKUclcIA?e=fuz4CP

⚥ Back to work: what to think about?

Of course it's great fun to share your experiences with colleagues, so be sure to tell them about your son or daughter! Sharing photos is also fun, of course.

Start slowly and let any changes and new colleagues come to you in the first week. Do you run into things that you do not know how to deal with? Then you can always contact HR or your Teamlead. If we know about it, we can think along with you.

♀ I would like to pump breast milk. What has been arranged for this?

If you are breastfeeding, you have the right to interrupt your work during the first nine months of your child's life to pump or feed your child. DiP offers you the opportunity to do so and provides a suitable lockable space. We have a nice place both at the Den Bosch and Amsterdam offices. Both with curtains and a lock on the door. In Den Bosch the flask room is the DB Tag Tank. In Amsterdam it is the AMS Conver Suite. You can just put the milk in both refrigerators.

Breaks take place as often and as long as necessary, but should not take up more than a quarter of your working time per day. The time spent feeding or pumping counts as working time. These hours are paid for.

♀♂ My child is sick, do I have to take time off?

If your child is sick and you are the only one who can care for him/her, you can claim care leave. Care leave is paid at 70%. You have to apply to HR in advance (before you take it).

Care leave does not apply if someone else takes care of your child. This can be your partner or family member or if your child is being cared for in a hospital.

Is your question not listed here? Ask HR or contact one of the mothers or fathers in our team. They are happy to think along with you!

Experiences from DiP mothers

The paradox is that it's the biggest thing in your life that can happen to you, but you shouldn't make it too big. You put an individual into the world, which in time makes his/her own decisions and doesn't always stay with you, you also hope he/she doesn't always stay with you. You also have to be able to let it go.

- Eiske

Experiences from DiP mothers

How did you announce you were pregnant and how did you feel about it?

Eiske: *"I called Annemiek and then René and Joachim. After that everyone saw/heard about it and they noticed at the office. I told the client in the morning during stand-up. I did wait until 14 weeks, by which time we had had an extensive ultrasound and also other test results back and I knew it was okay. If it had gone wrong before then I wouldn't have told at work."*

Marloes: *"After the term ultrasound, I told some colleagues in person. I was very happy, but it also seemed hard to tell because it didn't seem so convenient for my colleagues if I would be out of it for a while. They all reacted in a super positive and relaxed way and were very happy for me, so that worry was soon gone! When the NIPT results were also good, I posted a message on Teams to inform the rest of the team."*

How were the reactions of colleagues?

Eiske: *"Everyone was super positive and happy for me! You then also get everyone's stories about their kids, so I kind of liked it."*

Marloes: *"I got lots of congratulations and many people asked how I was doing, so very nice. It was strange to be pregnant in corona time: all the time people only saw my head on the webcam and didn't know much about my pregnancy. Whenever I was in the office, people would comment on my 'huge belly' that 'suddenly' appeared. However, that belly grew nicely on schedule and was definitely not there overnight."* 😉

Jasmijn: *"I got a lot of nice reactions from colleagues in the beginning! Like Marloes, I was pregnant in the heyday of corona, so it was just not visible to colleagues that I was pregnant. This was a bit of a shame, because I would have liked it if my colleagues could have followed my pregnancy a bit more 'actively'. This did lead to funny situations where colleagues I didn't talk to much were surprised when I told them I was about to leave because they hadn't even seen me pregnant."*

How did your pregnancy go in combination with work?

Eiske: *"Fine, no particulars. The only annoying thing was that I was supposed to go on leave at 36 weeks, but Arnoud was born at 35, so I didn't get to do my last rounding. Nobody gave me a hard time about that and because of the situation we were in I didn't worry about it. As long as my baby was doing well, I could forget about the rest just fine."*

Mieke: *"I found working quite difficult when I was pregnant. In the beginning I had a lot of ailments and ate almost nothing, which I found very difficult when I was in the office and had not told anyone yet (before 11 weeks). My tip: do tell 1 person, who can sometimes help you (e.g.: yell that she doesn't feel like sushi so you don't have to* 😉 *). At the end of the pregnancy I unfortunately had a lot of complications so I had to stop working early. (Another tip: just do it, you will never regret taking it easy, but if things don't work out and you have continued you will continue to feel guilty). Due to premature birth in combination with postpartum depression, I also spent longer at home at the end of my leave. Should there be anyone going through the same thing; they are always welcome to contact me!"*

Marloes: *"I was nauseous until week 21. Because I became pregnant during the corona period, I was working at home and in that sense it was convenient. I didn't notice that I had to eat something all the time or that I suddenly had very many pee breaks ;) I worked until 36 weeks, but found the last few weeks physically demanding. Pelvic pain combined with sitting at my computer all day was not ideal, but manageable because I could lie down at home every now and then. Mentally, though, it went fine: the transfer from my work to colleagues went very relaxed and I still had plenty of fun things to do until the end!*

Jasmijn: *"My pregnancy went pretty smoothly. I had few ailments and I was able to focus well on work. In this, I think it helped that I was pregnant during the corona period. I had no travel time to the office and I was able to take a moment for myself by sitting on the couch. A month before my leave, my assignment ended and I immediately started a new assignment. That was tough for a while. I felt I had to prove myself (to DiP and to the client) so I threw myself into it for 200%. That cost me a lot of energy, but when I brought that up with my Business Manager it was acted upon immediately and I was reassured."*

What concerns did you have, for example, about motherhood versus your work ambitions?

Eiske: *"No concerns really, but I did always think that you never know 100% how you think about it until you have a baby. In my case, I always wanted to keep working and now I know I want to. I am not the type of mother to be with my child every day. I think it's important for my development and happiness to be able to do my own thing. Arnoud, when it comes down to it, is the most important thing in my life, but when he's doing well, I also think it's important that I can keep doing my things and I take him to daycare with confidence."*

Marloes: *"I wanted to work less after my leave. Not always being present and available seemed difficult: both for myself because I would miss some things, and for colleagues whom I would not always be able to help. And are you still seen as fully committed when working part-time? I also wanted to guard against trying to cram a 40-hour work week into 28 hours after my leave."*

Jasmijn: *"Before I became pregnant, I was busy with internal projects at DiP, in addition to my assignments. I felt like I was working on 100 things at once and I really enjoyed doing that. But when I became pregnant, this started to scare me. After all, how would I later be able to fulfill my work ambitions even with a child?"*

How did you cope with that?

Marloes: *"I chose to work Mondays, Wednesdays and Fridays after my leave. On the days I'm not in the office, I do make sure I read my mail and respond to emergencies. That way I keep up to date and can still help colleagues relatively quickly. I also discussed with several colleagues my concern about not being seen as fully committed as a part-timer. They all indicated that they didn't see any problem with it, so that put my mind at ease. I also took a critical look at my duties & responsibilities and delegated or completed things in the run-up to my leave. That way, I was left with a realistic package to work on part-time. To learn even better how to deal with motherhood and work, I plan to take a course from Mominc toward the end of my leave (or after)."*

Jasmijn: *"It bothered me for quite a while (during my pregnancy and after) how best to handle the work-life balance. I wanted to give 120% at work 'because I wanted to show that being a mother did*

not affect my ambitions', I wanted to give 120% at home for my daughter and boyfriend and I also wanted to be a good daughter/sister/friend/etc. So not really realistic. Finding a good work-life balance was a challenge for me in the beginning, which caused some stress. I would therefore definitely recommend discussing this with DiP because once I had expressed my concerns I saw problems that were not there at all. I have now 'regained' my place at DiP and enjoy going to work again, but have had to accept that that 120% commitment I had before my pregnancy is now no longer realistic. And that's ok too!"

How did you feel about returning to work after your leave?

Eiske: *"Very nice: nice to see adults again and do my own thing again. Then at the end of the work day there is nothing nicer to pick up your little one again."*

Marloes: *"I was still in my baby bubble and wasn't really looking forward to going back to work. In fact, my colleagues were very happy that I was back, which helped enormously. It was a tough transition, but I really enjoyed being 'Marloes' again instead of just being a mom. Especially the first weeks I really had to switch gears (for example, I thought everyone was talking really fast haha!), but I was soon back into it!"*

Jasmijn: *"I was really looking forward to getting started! To work substantively with people again and then to see Lauren's sweet smile again at the end of the work day. To be honest, it took some getting used to working 8 hours in a row again. All meetings still digital, so you were really lived in, but after a few weeks I got into a rhythm with that too and blocked out moments in my schedule to grab a coffee or take a walk outside."*

What did you find the biggest challenge with this?

Marloes: *"Guarding my own limits. Not only mentally, but also physically. I still had pelvic pain and used my pump breaks to lie down for a while as well. Eventually, when my right to have paid pumping breaks ended, I called in sick for an hour a day for a while, so I could lie down in between. I was very upset about that, but there was no other way! To this day I try to cram a lot of work into few hours: that remains a challenge. Fortunately, I also really enjoy working hard!"*

How has motherhood made you work better?

Eiske: *"I experience less pressure. In the end, the most important thing is that your child is healthy and everything at work is relative. So I can put things into perspective better. But I also feel myself more 'complete' since becoming a mother, I have become a happier person because of it and I am incredibly grateful for that. So I am less strict with myself."*

Jasmijn: *"I notice that I am much more relaxed with work than before. I worry less and can put everything into perspective better. Whereas before my pregnancy I could get stressed if last-minute 10 deadlines came on my plate, now I can shrug it off more easily, just get to work and if it doesn't get finished think; 'tomorrow is another day'. I have become better at prioritizing work and can say 'no' more often as a result."*

Can you name one thing you didn't know beforehand, but would have like to know?

Eiske: *"I have become a happier person because of it. I suspected that beforehand; that's why we really wanted a baby, but I've always been aware that it might not have worked out and then you have to be able to deal with that."*

Do you have any golden tips for mothers-to-be? For example, what would you do differently with a second child (or what have you already done differently), or what do you wish you had known much earlier? What do you think all mothers should (not) do?

Eiske: *"Don't stress too much! There are billions of women who have already had children and they all could, well, almost all of them... The paradox is that it's the 'most big thing in your life that can happen to you, but you shouldn't make it too big. You put an individual into the world, which in time makes his/her own decisions and doesn't always stay with you, you also hope he/she doesn't always stay with you. You also have to be able to let it go. Other than that, I wouldn't do anything differently. I had arranged everything well in time. And I had to because Arnoud came too early, but by then we were largely ready. I had faith in myself and in my baby and it turned out that it worked out well."*

Marloes: *"If you want to breastfeed, I urge you to only stop this if it does not work out for you, or if you want to stop yourself. You really don't have to stop because it's not convenient in conjunction with your work. If you run into challenges with this, you can always call me! And: do what works for you and your baby right now. Don't let people who ask you if your child can do this or that fool you. If your gut tells you otherwise, it's fine to deviate from the norm.""*

You can always reach out to these moms for questions, inspiration or to share your concerns:

Eiske **Jasmijn** **Marloes** **Mariska** **Astrid** **Mieke**

Something on your mind? You can always contact Annemiek, she's our confidant.

Experiences from DiP fathers

Watching a child grow up is really beautiful. Of course, your off-season vacations with irregular dinner times and long evenings on the patio are over. In contrast, seeing a new little person discover the world, make their own choices and grow in life is really a lot of fun. If there is anything I have learned from this, it is that small things can be very beautiful.

- Rogier

Experiences from DiP fathers

How did you announce that you were going to be a father and how did you feel about it?

Olaf: *"Immediately when we knew we were possibly going to become parents we told family, colleagues and friends. We told it right away and didn't wait until 12 weeks, purely because of the fact that it went wrong for some in our environment within but also outside the 12 week period. We wanted people around us, that we spend a lot of time with, from day 1 to be able to share our joy but also our sorrow."*

Johan*: "I sent an email to the whole team, but on Friday at 4 p.m. so it could be celebrated right away. This was especially exciting because I had kept it a secret for a while."*

René de Boer: "I told it at the L@L day in front of the whole group, under the heading of personal growth. This felt like a good and personal moment for me to mention it directly to most of our colleagues anyway. And you have immediate interaction."

How were the reactions from colleagues?

Olaf: *"Super cool reactions and warm feelings, sweet messages...a lot of colleagues who as soon as they know about it also come back to it regularly to hear or know more."*

René de Boer: "Nice and positive. Everyone thinks you deserve it and wish you the best. And I also know that having a baby is not given to everyone, so it's really special."

How was the period prior to giving birth in combination with work?

Olaf: *"Since Patty herself was very lighthearted about the whole pregnancy thing, it was very easy. Fortunately, everything went very smoothly for us and from work they took everything into account towards giving birth."*

Johan: *"I especially remember that from a certain moment (week 36/37) you stop picking up 'big' things for a while, and maybe turn up the sound on your phone."*

René de Boer: "*Anika already had two babies and thus had the necessary experience with pregnancy. This ensured that many things were not necessarily very new. They were for me, but I could then discuss that well with Anika. I did do that, looked everything up and discussed it, so I didn't make any assumptions 😊. The combination of work and pregnancy went very well for us. Anika worked 2 days a week at that time (still does by the way). This also allowed me to continue working as usual, occasionally providing some extra support with the older kids, but this went naturally."*

What concerns did you have, for example about fatherhood versus your work ambitions?

Olaf: *"No worries at all, apart from taking leave only once the delivery had taken place. Really no worries at all since I knew everyone was there for me."*

Rogier: *"In terms of work ambitions, I always felt that this was perfectly manageable. Of course it is a puzzle, but the assignments you work on have colleagues who have children and they understand very well that you have to go away once in a while to pick up the little one. This fits well together,*

provided you also realize that it is a busy time. There is less time for yourself. I too came to work to rest. ;)"

René de Boer: *"I didn't necessarily have any worries. But whether we could have a healthy child. This is where my worries were. How will the two oldest boys react to this, what will change for them etc. Beforehand we discussed what I was doing with work and where my ambitions lay, so this was clear to us. We made the decision together that I would continue to work full-time and that Anika would continue to work a maximum of 2 days and also take on most of the care of the kids. So we made a joint decision on this. We also decided that in case we split up, that the division would be 50/50, since we made, in our eyes, conscious choices for the current situation."*

How did you deal with that?

René de Boer: *"Talking a lot with Anika and people directly around me. But especially with Anika and how we stand in this. It's a bit tedious perhaps, but thinking ahead and also outlining the scenario that you will split up should be included in this. And also to have faith in yourself and your partner that you will fix it together. Things can come up that you can't plan for in advance and you have to solve them together."*

How did you feel about returning to work after your paternity leave?

Olaf: *"Of course it's tough when you've had about three weeks off (including normal vacations) and then you have to get back to work. On the other hand, it's good to get away from it all and have something else to say at home besides bottles, breastfeeding and diapers. On the other hand, it's not that important anymore."*

Johan: *"It was especially strange to leave home behind and get involved in work things again. But that felt normal again after a few days. In terms of challenges, it is especially difficult that when you come home there is also a second job waiting for you. Especially in the first 3 months there is no real possibility of relaxing in the evenings. In that respect, work is perhaps the very place where you can recover, so don't expect to be as productive as before either."*

René de Boer: "*Going back to work the first day and, to my mind, leaving your partner behind with the kids felt pretty crazy. So that first day I really wanted to go home on time too* 😊*. Fortunately, we also have work that is relatively easy to do from home and during non-office hours. Other than that, I also enjoyed going back to work. I see that as an important way of taking care of your family anyway. The first few weeks I spread out my leave over several days, so working in the mornings and then being home in the afternoon. Nowadays it is good that fathers have longer leave than the 2 days it used to be. From DiP, we already gave the fathers an extra 5 days to provide more time for this."*

What did you find the biggest challenges in this?

Olaf: *"The toughest thing is that while you are at work you don't get the changes at home. Especially in the first weeks/months they go so fast in their development that you actually always want to be there. You then get to hear in the evening that he/she did this or that this afternoon, something you were normally called in to when it happened. Eventually after years you find out that something is always changing in their life and development. You just can't be there all the time."*

René de Boer: *"In this I didn't really have any major challenges, I think mainly your sense of responsibility feels a bit crazy. The idea of leaving your family behind was crazy to me. I had every*

confidence that Anika would be fine, but I still had the idea 'What if something happens?' Anika has gone through childbirth, so she also needs to rest and be able to enjoy herself. This was the biggest challenge for me: organizing it well according to my believe and by working also taking the responsibility to be able to take care of my family."

How has fatherhood made your work better?

Olaf: *"For me now, on the one hand, work is a wonderful escape; on the other hand, I now recognize certain things about myself better in relation to three teenagers at home. I sometimes see things happening at work or have to address people...that on the way home I think, well then we'll just do it all over again at home. In that respect, sometimes there is not very much difference in dealing with colleagues or with your teenage sons."*

Rogier: *"I can put my work into perspective more and more. What seemed SUPER important is actually not nearly as important. The world doesn't end if you don't work for a day."*

Johan: *"It has become easier to take work less seriously because I already have another high priority in my life by default. For me, this was an advantage because it also made work easier to prioritize, so I say no more often."*

René de Boer: "*Fatherhood teaches me to look at things in different ways. Children sometimes really look at things in a very different way. In a way, it has also taught me to plan better. To still make the necessary contribution at home* 😊*. In addition, it has given me much more understanding for other people: what it means to have children and how much impact it has on you. It has also taught me that you can still pursue your ambitions, in other words, it's not an excuse not to do something: it's a choice you make. That choice is yours and so I also like that everyone has their own take on this."*

Can you name one thing you didn't know beforehand but would have liked to know?

Olaf: *"With the first one, you both have to enjoy very hard the freedom you still have with the three of you. As soon as a second comes along, the first one is much more of a hand basket."*

René de Boer: *"I underestimated what visiting does to you. Everyone feels the need to visit, which is also super nice, but you really are completely lived. This puts you at risk of not being able to enjoy the first days/moments sufficiently. The arrival of a child is truly a unique moment and if you are constantly surrounded by people, it is difficult to give it a place. We handled this differently with the 4th child. We spread the visits out over a much longer period of time and really asked people to come by at a later time. If you explain this, they really understand."*

Do you have any golden tips for expectant fathers? For example, what would you do differently with a second (or what have you already done differently), or what do you wish you had known much earlier? What should all fathers (not) do in your opinion?

Olaf: *"Make sure that the first few weeks there are only two parts of the day for visits. Morning and/or afternoon and/or evening, so not all three. Grandparents can always come by, but when mommy and the little one are sleeping, then they SLEEP, and don't get woken up!"*

Johan*: "Maternity visitors really don't all have to come in the 1st week. After a month the baby is still new too. In addition, try not to take tips & tricks that you get from other people, or via the internet, too seriously and find out what you yourself find the nicest way of handling things. It can become quite stressful to always be thinking about how other people do things. Basically, no one knows how*

to do things with the first one, and every child is different. So with all those stories on the Internet there are a lot of 'n=1' solutions that I wouldn't take too seriously."

René de Boer: *"Enjoy this unique moment. And this all sounds a bit cliché, but it really is. Accept that things will go differently than you thought of beforehand. Your baby will regularly think differently and 'throw a spanner in the works'. You can get very upset about this or move a little bit with it and not worry. This makes it more enjoyable for everything and everyone."*

Make sure you have a good work-life balance. This one is different for everyone. And discuss this well at home, so there can be no misunderstandings. This also allows you to think well in advance about how you might want to arrange childcare if needed. This will take more time than you think.

In general, I expect you will find that you think differently about parenting. This is not a bad thing and you will have to accept this from each other. You will have to keep discussing this so that you can make an agreement about how you want to deal with this. If you don't discuss it, you will get frustrations between the parents. This is somewhat less in the early days, but certainly as they get older and more mischievous, this will come into play. To this day, I find it a challenge to do this as best I can. Perhaps other parents don't have this at all, that could well be the case. For me, though, it's something I wish I had addressed earlier.

Overall, there is so much to say and share with each other, so let's especially encourage each other to talk to each other about this. Fun!"

You can always reach out to these dads for questions, inspiration or to share your concerns:

Johan

Oguz

Olaf

René

Something on your mind? You can always contact Annemiek, she's our confidant.

Planner

A pregnancy lasts between 37 and 42 weeks in most cases (a few weeks shorter in twins). The due date is calculated at 40 weeks after the first day of the mother's last period. 40 weeks is a long time, but also remember that it is a super special time. Every week your baby grows into a complete human being. Meanwhile, every day you get one day closer to parenthood. Time to put things in order!

Week 8	It feels very early and something you don't need to take care of right now, but if you are planning to arrange childcare, you can't start early enough. If you live in the Randstad, you might even have been better off signing up your child before it was even made... Avoid problems with long waiting lists and start looking around. This will get you right into baby mode! This is also the week when some midwives offer a ''fun ultrasound''. After all, as of now, the baby's heart is already beating!
Week 12	Time to arrange maternity care. The midwife's office can recommend an organization or ask friends in the neighbourhood. The midwife will schedule a term ultrasound with you to determine the due date. After this, the mother's blood will also be checked and you will be given information about NIPT. Many people choose to share the big news with everyone around this time: enjoy!
Week 13-19	Are you curious if you are having a daughter or a son? During this period, you can have a ''fun ultrasound'' to determine the gender. Insider tip: on your way back, stop by the supermarket for your first biscuit!
Week 20	An exciting moment: during the 20-week medical ultrasound, your baby is examined from head to toe. Is the spine nicely closed, does it have two hands and no clubfeet? Is the stomach full, is the bladder working and is the supply of nutrients via the placenta good? Meanwhile, you and your partner watch in amazement at the little person waving at you from the mother's belly. Around this time you can order a maternity package through your health insurance company, which will be delivered around the 6th/7th month of pregnancy. If you are not insured for this, you pay a contribution of a few tens of dollars. You can also order a package yourself via bol.com or Dalalou, of course.
Week 22+	Through the midwife you will receive information about the 22 week shot, also known as the whooping cough vaccination. When you get vaccinated as a mother, your baby is immediately protected against whooping cough, diphtheria and tetanus. You can have this done from 22 weeks until the end of pregnancy. RIVM recommends not waiting too long, as you want to make sure you have it taken care of before delivery.
Week 30	Around this time it is convenient to order maternity care supplies. Whether you want to give birth at home or in the hospital, if your bed is lower than 80 cm, you need to order bed risers. These are covered by your health insurance company. Your maternity care provider can also order the equipment you want.
Week 33	Around this time you should have had an intake interview with the maternity care provider. If not, you should find out soon!
Week 35	Time to discuss your birth plan and wishes with the midwife or gynecologist. Prepare well, together with your partner: this way you remain in control and you can look back on the birth with pleasure, even if it did not turn out the way you had hoped.

Planner

If you are not such a tight planner, you will naturally become one once your child arrives. You won't be the first to find out at the end of the afternoon that your partner has made plans as well for tonight. But then again, who stays with the baby? We share with you some important things you need to plan and take care of anyway.

Types of leave

DIGITAL POWER

You're having a baby!

What are you entitled to?

16 weeks of leave

Childbirth

Child 8 years

	Pregnancy leave	Maternity leave	Parental leave	Parental leave
Mother	4 to 6 weeks	10 to 12 weeks	0 to 9 weeks, valid 1 year from childbirth	17 to 26 weeks, valid 7 years from childbirth
	100% paid	100% paid	70% paid	Unpaid

	Partner leave	Extended partner leave	Parental leave	Parental leave
Partner	1 workweek in first 4 weeks	0 to 5 weeks, valid 6 months from childbirth	0 to 9 weeks, valid 1 year from childbirth	17 to 26 weeks, valid 7 years from childbirth
	100% paid	70% paid	70% paid	Unpaid

Inspiration for parents

As a new parent, there is no need to reinvent the wheel. Although you can of course google it yourself, we would like to give you some personal tips.

Inspiration for parents

Things you didn’t know

- ♀♂ It is best to arrange for maternity care as soon as possible. Especially in big cities, there are substantial waiting lists. You might not think about that already, but do it anyway. You can always cancel or switch! Actually, the same goes for childcare.
- ♀♂ If you feel uncomfortable with maternity care, SWITCH!!! It is essential that you feel cared for and comfortable with the help.
- ♀♂ Planning to breastfeed? Visit an information evening from your midwife or hospital or participate in a webinar about it. Do this together with your partner: you will be amazed at the amount of information there is and at how big a role the partner can play.
- ♀♂ Rompers are made for pulling off the shoulders in case of an exploded diaper. By the way, the special opening also makes them easier to pull over a baby's head than a regular shirt.
- ♀ Want to breastfeed, but you can't (for a while)? In case of newborns or only after months (that's possible, in fact), call a lactation consultant. They can take away a lot of frustration. And frustration is not uncommon! There are also several organizations that offer a "breastfeeding helpline" that you can call anytime.
- ♀ Your belly is going to get in the way when you're at your desk. Make sure (even better than usual) that you regularly change positions and keep moving during a workday.

Fun apps

Oudersvannu

Nice app that you check in the morning for the "tip of the day. Through the app you can also read all kinds of articles and participate in the forum.

Oudersvannu's magazine is also worth checking out!

Zwangerschap+

An app in partnership with Philips Avent, where you can read daily blogs and weekly compare your little one in size and weight with an animal or fruit, among other things.

Each week you will read new information about baby growth, changes in the female body, tips for partners and specific info about pregnancies with twins.

Howaboutmom

A beautiful app that is not necessarily about baby development, but about your transformation from woman to mother.

Read beautiful quotes, honest stories, take free mini courses and discover what is happening to your body.

There is also a book with the same title!

ZwangerHap

Not sure whether or not something is safe to eat (or serve to your pregnant partner)? You can use this app from the Nutrition Center to check for each ingredient whether it is safe to eat during pregnancy.

A **contraction timer app** to measure the length of contractions and pauses in between during labour.

Also helpful:

The (paid) **Oei ik groei app**, which allows you to interpret your baby's "leaps" in growth (and thus his/her sudden mood swings).

The **Baby+ app**: the sequel to the Pregnancy+ app.

Book tips

♀♂ **Het boek waarvan je wilde dat je ouders het hadden gelezen:** a book that can give you beautiful insights and conversations with your partner!

♀♂ **De eerste 1000 dagen:** scientifically based book about the various factors that play a role in the development of your child, from the day of conception until he/she is 2 years old.

♀♂ **Oei ik groei:** a practical book that explains the growth and development of your child (and the challenges and behavioural changes involved). Nice to have once your baby is born, however of course it is not a manual 😉

By the way, it has not been scientifically proven that babies go through these "development phases" at the same times, so you have to let those weeks go a bit. But sometimes it's nice to be able to think: it's probably a jump!

♀♂ **Cribsheet: A Data-Driven Guide to Better, More Relaxed Parenting, From Birth to Preschool" by Emily Oster.** She is a Professor of Economics who became pregnant and wanted to know what was actually true about parenting (such as bottle vs. breastfeeding, sleep training, and attachment, etc.). She sifted through all the scientific literature and compiled her findings. Conclusion: don't go crazy, everyone just says what they want.

♀ **Mama'en:** When a child is born, a mother is also born. This book helps you reflect on the special time of your pregnancy and the postpartum period.

♀ **How about mom**: This book also focuses on you as a woman becoming a mother. It has some overlap with Mama'en, but mainly focuses on the postpartum period. How do you deal with visitors, pumping, and the end of your leave, for example?

♀ **Positief over bevallen**: A must-read for women who want to look forward to the day they meet their child with confidence and curiosity, rather than fear and reluctance. It also provides valuable and practical insights to share with your partner.

♀ **Krijg nou tieten**: Geweldig boek van Claudia de Breij.

♀ **De vrije geboorte:** a book that can give you a lot of insights about the "natural way" of childbirth versus a "medical childbirth." How do you give birth in the most positive way and make sure you make choices that suit you?

♂ **Kickstart je vaderschap:** On the emancipation of fathers. It is often wrongly claimed that mothers are better caregivers (the well-known motherly feeling) and fathers are seen as fools who don't understand how to deal with a baby, but that is, of course, complete nonsense! It is just a matter of making time, gaining experience, and getting to know your child. A book with practical tips for fathers.

- ♂ **Help, ik heb mijn vrouw zwanger gemaakt:** Funny book by Kluun, written for expectant fathers. Take the information with a grain of salt and don't read some passages to your pregnant partner 😜

- ♂ **Handboek voor vaders: How to survive in the jungle of fatherhood:** a down-to-earth men's book with humor that's not about children, but about you as an (expectant) father.

- ♂ **Aanpakken voor aanstaande vaders**: a practical, informative guide for expectant fathers, written by a male midwife. Not a funny book, but definitely a book that is useful.

Podcasts

♀ **Podnataal**: Dynamic podcast with short stories from the real life of a pregnant woman. Nice to listen to from the beginning of your pregnancy.

♀ **De verwachting**: Positive childbirth stories about all scenarios you can imagine. Nice to listen to in preparation for your childbirth.

♀ **Mama'en:** Extensive conversations with all kinds of specialists from the "childbirth world." Very interesting if you really want to reflect on the fact that you are becoming a mother.

♀ **Mama doet ook maar wat**: Lovely, down-to-earth conversations with mothers about their experiences with motherhood.

Websites

♀♂ **Gezinopreis.nl:** Inspiring site with handy and fun ideas for traveling with mini travel companions (Chantal and her family have also contributed something: www.gezinopreis.nl/interview-interrailen-met-kinderen.

♂ **De vaderschapskalender**: pregnancy month by month. What approximately happens and what can you expect? www.24baby.nl/vaderschapskalender

Personal tips for your baby supply list

You can understand that you need a crib and a stack of diapers. There are also plenty of checklist to find online! Determine what you need for yourself, but don't forget to read your colleagues' tips.

Personal tips for your baby supply list

- **Hirsch Natur socks,** which don't come off due to the bow.
- **Wraparound romper suits;** a lot easier to dress newborns because you don't have to pull them over the head!
- **Woolen baby clothes and blankets:** this keeps your baby optimally at the right temperature in any season. Don't dress your baby too warm: the temperature in the neck is the perfect indication of whether they are warm/cold.
- **Puckababy sleeping bag**. When buying sleeping bags and pyjamas, pay attention to the TOG value. Your baby needs a warmer/cooler sleep outfit depending on the season and temperature. https://www.24baby.nl/baby/verzorging-baby/togwaarde/
- **Do you have a difficult sleeper?** Some babies are very active or quickly become overstimulated. Then it is difficult to get them back to rest. Limiting the body can then work well (back in the womb!). Start with a **Nunki blanket**: that is safer than swaddling, and for some babies is already sufficient. They are quite expensive, but you can also find them on marktplaats or rent them if you want to try it out. **If this doesn't work? Consider swaddling**. There are many types and sizes of swaddle cloths and bags. You can ask Anika Batenburg which ones she has tried and what the pros/cons are.
- **A feeding pillow.** You can purchase this halfway through your pregnancy so you can sleep comfortably on it. It is also good for your pelvis/hips/stomach as your pregnancy progresses and you sleep on your side. Once the baby is here, put the pillow on your lap and the baby can "sit" on it during feedings. For example, the Doomoo Buddy.
- **Mirror for car seat in the back:** hiermee kun je, als je aan het rijden bent, via je achteruitkijkspiegel je baby zien zitten in het autostoeltje.
- **For big purchases**, keep an eye on websites such as Prénatal, Babydump, Babypark, bol.com, etc. They often have deals that allow you to purchase items such as strollers, Maxi-Cosi, etc. at a discount. Don't forget Marktplaats, it's full of baby stuff.
- Bol.com often has good deals on diapers, or check out luieraanbiedingen.nl. Lidl and AH diapers are excellent after sizes 0 and 1. Kruidvat diapers also consistently come out on top in tests! That saves quite a bit of money! And most importantly, they don't leak.
- **Cloth diapers**: you might think, yikes and complicated! But it's not that bad. These days you have very handy diapers that you can close with Velcro or snap buttons. You throw the dirty diapers in a special bucket with a wash bag, and you can put the wash bag in the washing machine all at once. So you don't have to touch dirty diapers. They have very cute prints and it's also much better for the environment and your baby's bottom -> no waste and no chemicals! And ultimately also positive for your wallet.
- **Hydrofiber cloths** are handy for everything (swaddling, feeding, etc.), so buy enough of them. There are many small businesses on well-known websites or on Instagram that make them in cute colors and patterns for an affordable price.
- Look on **Marktplaats** for items such as a playpen, crib, co-sleeper, high chair (Tripp Trapp with newborn set is recommended), clothing closet, ….
- Consider buying a **baby carrier**. You have your hands free to live your life and your child feels warm and secure with you. Especially when they are still so small and want to be with you all day. Most children sleep wonderfully in them. For the adventurous (backpackers) among us:

    - Babycot
    - Babycot
- A **joint calendar**. Especially after the arrival of your first child, it is a useful tool to coordinate your planning with each other. You won't be the first to both plan a night out and "just" forget that someone needs to be home with the baby. For example, the 'Klender'.

And one more thing.

Children are not difficult.

Children are different.

And that can be quite difficult.

Remember that the experiences of others do not necessarily have to be your own experiences. That something that someone else finds useful may not necessarily be necessary for you. That it's okay to make mistakes, that it's okay not to enjoy it sometimes, and that you are giving your children a wonderful example by showing them that you are still learning and do not know or do everything perfectly.

Enjoy, be proud, and know that you are never alone.

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